ABOUT THIS PIECE

Literature circles unit: resilience

Katherine Conklin

WHAT IT IS

A literature circles unit for 5th grade on resilience: three trade books, five roles, and groups that meet twice a week for four weeks. Written for class and used with students.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

How one theme ties three books together across a unit.

The work itself starts on the next page.

5TH GRADE · EDU 332: READING STRATEGIES IN HISTORY

Exploring Resilience Through Literature

A Literature Circles Unit — Three Books, Five Roles, One Theme

STANDARDS
ELA 5.8 & 5.4 · SS 5.5 — text structure, context clues, historical impact

STRUCTURE
Groups meet 2x weekly for 4 weeks

THEME
Resilience in the Face of Adversity

Theme & Purpose

This unit explores how individuals demonstrate determination, courage, and strength when facing challenges. Students connect the theme to characters across three trade books, then reflect on its relevance in their own lives.

Trade Books

The Hunger Games — Suzanne Collins
Katniss Everdeen navigates a dystopian world where survival depends on resilience, courage, and strategy.

"I volunteer as tribute!"

The Outsiders — S.E. Hinton
Ponyboy Curtis and the Greasers face societal prejudice and personal struggle, learning the value of family and self-discovery.

"Things are rough all over, but it was better that way. That way, you could tell the other guy was human too."

Charlotte's Web — E.B. White
Wilbur the pig learns the importance of friendship and perseverance through his spider friend, Charlotte.

"You have been my friend. That in itself is a tremendous thing."

Group Roles

Role	Responsibility
Discussion Director	Prepares thought-provoking, open-ended questions ("What if…?" "Why did…?")
Summarizer	Recaps key events, characters, and themes
Connector	Links the text to personal experience, other books, or historical events
Vocabulary Enricher	Explains challenging words from the text
Illustrator	Creates a visual representation of a key moment or theme

Scaffolding Materials

Discussion prompts such as “What part of the book surprised you, and why?” and “How does this scene connect to something in your life?” A **Character Resilience Map** tracks each character's challenge, reaction, traits demonstrated, and outcome. A **Reflection Journal** supports before-and-after discussion reflections and self-assessment of participation.

Differentiation

Struggling readers are paired with peers for collaborative support, visual aids reinforce key concepts, and sentence starters scaffold reflective writing for students who need it.

Assessment

Assessment Type	Details
Teacher observation	Group discussion participation and dynamics
Self-evaluation	Checklists and reflection forms
Role-specific rubric	Active participation: 5 pts · Occasional input: 3 pts · Minimal: 1 pt

Reflection Questions

“What did you learn about resilience from this book?” · “How did discussing with your group change your perspective?”